THE ARAKAN NATIONAL PARTY AND RAKHINE ETHNO-NATIONALISM

Rakhine State had exceptional circumstances, which influenced the election results in the state. The largest communal violence in Myanmar occurred in the state between 2012 and 2013 (ICG 2013; Kipgen 2013; Walton and Hayward 2014). While the communal antagonism continued through ongoing segregation and continuous political mobilizations on communal issues, such as the inclusion or exclusion of 'Rohingya' as an ethnic identity in the census process, attacks against INGO offices in Sittwe and rejection of the voting rights of white-card holders (Min Zin 2015) inflamed the situation.

The white-card voting right cancellation was significant because most people from Muslim communities in Rakhine State were not able to vote in 2015, although they had participated in the 2010 election (Lun Min Mang 2015; Samet 2015). This changed the composition of voters in many townships, especially in Maungdaw District. Before the 2010 election, the military junta issued 750,000 Temporary National Identity Cards or 'white cards' in Rakhine State for the people who are controversially referred to as 'Bengalis' or 'Rohingya'. The USDP received a considerable proportion of votes from the Muslim community with a large number of white card voters, and it won seats with Muslim representatives in Maungdaw and Buthidaung townships in 2010 (O'Toole 2014). The cancellation of white card voters' rights massively reduced the size of these constituencies and removed the Muslim population from the vote. In 2010, 211,328 people in Maungdaw township lodged valid votes, and in Buthidaung there were 129,909 people.[2] The eligible voter numbers would still have been higher than these figures. For the 2015 election, Myanmar's Union Election Commission (UEC) reported eligible voters in Maungdaw were just 24,008, and in Buthidaung, 36,069. Moreover, the Commission also disqualified Muslim candidates, citing citizenship issues over their parents' identities and backgrounds (Ei Ei Toe Lwin 2015). This resulted in only Buddhist candidates standing in these townships. As a direct consequence, the overwhelming majority of the residents in Maungdaw and some people in Sittwe District were unable to vote in the 2015 election (Long 2015b). Furthermore, it made less electoral competition for the ANP candidates in these constituencies.

These circumstances contributed quite significantly to the Buddhist